despite becoming the president of India in July 1982, Giani Zail Singh had played a dubious role in what had happened.

Zail Singh, who had carried tales regarding Swaran Singh in the immediate aftermath of the declaration of Emergency, citing Singh's open criticism of the move, did not want any Sikh leader to get the credit for solving the Punjab imbroglio. He reportedly told Indira Gandhi that credit for solving the Punjab problem should go to Rajiv Gandhi, as it would help the fledgling politician build his reputation as a national-level political leader. [20]

Referring to the failure of the talks, Mark Tully and Satish Jacob mention in their book that Swaran Singh 'was bitterly disappointed and never became involved in the negotiations again'. [21]

Asian Games shenanigans

The Akali leaders, who were waiting at the SGPC office in Amritsar for the home minister's statement on 4 November, were stunned by the betrayal and in response immediately issued a threat to disrupt the ninth Asian Games in order to focus world attention on the 'persecution of the Sikhs in India'. [22] The Games were to be held in New Delhi from 19 November to 4 December 1982.

Meanwhile, a short one-act play began in New Delhi, with its stated aim being to yet again find a peaceful solution to the Punjab problem. The main actors this time were Rajiv Gandhi, Amarinder Singh and a couple of Rajiv's close friends from the 1 Akbar Road group, and Badal, Balwant Singh, Ravi Inder Singh (former speaker of the Punjab assembly) and R.S. Bhatia representing the Akalis. The government was represented by Defence Minister R. Venkataraman, Home Minister P.C. Sethi, Law Minister P. Shiv Shankar, Home Secretary T.N. Chaturvedi and Principal Secretary to the PM P.C. Alexander.

According to Alexander, the meeting was called at Amarinder Singh's instance. Amarinder suggested that the government consider holding informal talks at a level lower than the PM's. However, according to Chawla, the idea for these talks actually came from Giani Zail Singh so that credit for their success might go to Rajiv